

# Cover story **SACHIN TENDULKAR**

the same conditions, at the same pace, when your mind is free you have time to play your shots; when you have too many thoughts in your mind, you are late." It is something all great sportsmen have talked about; the quality of the mind influencing the quality of the stroke. His ability to stay focussed has often separated him from the rest.

Maybe that is why he has rarely lost his composure on a cricket ground. He has shown disappointment, but rarely anger. I have often marvelled at this ability to stay calm amidst extreme provocation. Maybe that is the secret of his ability and indeed, of his longevity, for a calm cricketer is a more dangerous cricketer with the mind uncluttered by thoughts of vengeance and anger. Maybe that is what separates him from Brian Lara, the other genuinely great cricketer of his era.

Lara was an astonishingly skilled sportsman and like Tendulkar took on the opposition and vanquished it with extraordinary stroke-play. But occasionally Lara's mind would wander away into a dangerous zone and he could be his own enemy. In the art of batsmanship, they were equals; indeed Lara sometimes took the art to more sublime levels, but it was Tendulkar's composure that gave him greater consistency.

Only once in the years that I have known him have I sensed a weariness, have I seen Tendulkar contemplating life outside cricket. Plagued by one injury after another he was very keen to play in the IPL, but a persistent groin injury kept troubling him. The recovery was painful but just as agonising was the fact that he was around the game but unable to play it. Constant injury meant mind and body weren't walking in step, that he was fighting on two fronts. "I'm sick of this rehab," he suddenly announced, and in doing so allowed those around him a rare exposure to the frustrations that were dogging him. But he fought injury, did

**TENDULKAR WITH WIFE ANJALI AND KIDS ARJUN AND SARA AT THE UNVEILING OF HIS WAX FIGURE AT MADAME TUSSAUDS**

REUTERS



**In ODIs, he has 58 Man of the Match awards which is a**

